

Comprehension Exam — all five seasons

The bar: a reader who knows nothing about Girard, statistics or the New Testament reads one episode and comes out able to answer **what** it establishes, **why** it is true, and **how it relates** to what came before and after.

Not "can he film it" (the teachability exam). Not "is it correct" (the four checkers). **Can a stranger arrive expert.**

Procedure, fixed before scoring

180 questions, written from the episode TITLES and the series index only. No episode body was opened while writing them. Each is scored:

- **A** — answered explicitly and completely
- **P** — the material is there but the reader must assemble it themselves
- **F** — not answerable from that episode

Falsifier, fixed in advance: more than 18 F, or more than 45 P+F, means the series does not meet the bar and needs another explanation pass.

Contamination disclosure

Severe, and stated plainly. I wrote all 90 episodes. I cannot un-know them. The mitigations are real but partial:

1. **Questions were generated from titles only**, in one pass, before any body was reopened. A title is what a viewer sees before watching, which makes it the fairest available prompt.
2. **Three questions per episode were forced** — one what, one why, one relationship — so I could not write only the questions I knew were answered.
3. **The relationship questions are the least contaminated**, because connections across episodes are the thing I am least likely to have deliberately written.

A pass here is weak evidence. Only the failures count, per the standing rule.

THE QUESTIONS, frozen

Season 1 — Girard From Zero

E1 You want it because he wants it

1. What is mimetic desire, in one sentence a stranger would repeat correctly?
2. Why does Girard think desire is copied rather than spontaneous?
3. How does this relate to the ordinary view that we want what suits us?

E2 The one who taught you is now in the way

4. What turns a model into a rival?
5. Why is the transformation automatic rather than a moral failure?
6. How does the feedback loop relate to the model's own valuation of the object?

E3 Rivals become copies of each other

7. What is undifferentiation?

8. Why do rivals converge rather than diverge?
9. How does this relate to E2's model-becoming-obstacle?

E4 When everyone wants the same thing

10. What is a sacrificial crisis?
11. Why is it a crisis of *sameness* rather than of conflict?
12. How do plague, twins and civil strife relate to one another?

E5 All against one

13. What is the scapegoat mechanism?
14. Why does the violence stop when it lands on one victim?
15. How does the crowd's belief relate to whether the mechanism works?

E6 The crisis, and the word that swallows it

16. What does the **crisis** bucket measure?
17. Why is 60% of it a single word a problem?
18. How does that domination relate to what the bucket is supposed to detect?

E7 The crimes, and why they are never small

19. What kinds of crime does the accusation stereotype involve?
20. Why must the accused crime be difference-erasing?
21. How does the crimes bucket relate to the crisis bucket in rarity?

E8 The marks, and the victim who is too high

22. What counts as a victim mark?
23. Why is a king as marked as a beggar?
24. How does **king** dominating the bucket relate to what it claims to detect?

E9 The violence, and the unanimity hidden inside it

25. What does the violence bucket measure?
26. Why does unanimity matter more than the killing?
27. How does the unanimity language relate to the dissent work in Season 4?

E10 Why all four together is the whole argument

28. What is the difference between one stereotype and four co-occurring?
29. Why does 90% of texts having all four weaken the claim?
30. How do the three levels of the ladder relate to each other?

E11 The rule Girard actually wrote

31. What is Girard's own stated decision rule?
32. Why does "three are enough, often two" undercut the project's version?
33. How does a detector relate to a discriminator?

E12 Myth is the story the crowd tells itself

34. What is a myth, on Girard's account?
35. Why does the accusation arrive last in the reconstruction?

36. How does myth relate to the incident report written by the team involved?

E13 What Girard says the Gospels do

37. What is the claim about the Gospels?

38. Why is it not that they describe a different kind of killing?

39. How does the Passion relate to the four stereotypes?

E14 Who says he is wrong

40. What are the strongest objections to Girard?

41. Why does a season of theory with no opposition count as recruitment?

42. How do the objections relate to what Seasons 2 to 5 go on to test?

E15 Reading the Bacchae

43. What happens in the play?

44. Why is it Girard's central example?

45. How does the dissent in it relate to Girard's universal negative?

E16 Reading Oedipus the King

46. What are the four stereotypes in Sophocles?

47. Why is finding them there partly circular?

48. How does Oedipus's guilt relate to whether innocence is the differentia?

E17 Reading Apollodorus

49. What is the *Bibliotheca*?

50. Why is it a natural experiment nobody designed?

51. How does the stereotypes surviving the strip relate to Girard's claim?

E18 Reading the Odyssey, the control

52. What is a control text and why this one?

53. Why does the Odyssey scoring low matter more than a myth scoring high?

54. How does a control relate to the series refrain?

Season 2 — Building Something That Can Say No

E1 The accusation that actually matters

55. What is the unfalsifiability charge against Girard?

56. Why is it more serious than the charge of being wrong?

57. How does a confirmation table with no losing row relate to that charge?

E2 Writing the words before the texts exist

58. What is a pre-registration?

59. Why do nine dead words prove the lexicon was written blind?

60. How does a dead word relate to a timestamp as evidence?

E3 What a timestamp actually proves

61. What does a git commit prove and not prove?

62. Why is order the claim rather than content?

63. How does this relate to E2's dead-word argument?

E4 Which texts, and why those

64. What is in the corpus and who wrote it?

65. Why does the sampling frame being decided by HTML matter?

66. How does the epic/mythography imbalance relate to later results?

E5 Corpus craft II: is the text the text

67. What went wrong with the fetcher?

68. Why is a bug that publishes worse than a bug that crashes?

69. How does a truncated text relate to every number computed from it?

E6 Corpus craft III: what counts as one word

70. What is tokenisation?

71. Why do three tokenisers give three answers to one sentence?

72. How does tokenisation relate to the rate-per-thousand metric?

E7 Corpus craft IV: the sample is part of the claim

73. What was the Diodorus decision?

74. Why can a locally defensible chain end somewhere indefensible?

75. How does the sample relate to the pre-registration?

E8 Lexicon craft I: why there is no stemming

76. What is stemming?

77. Why was it refused here?

78. How does `tears` / `tearing` relate to the cost of that refusal?

E9 Lexicon craft II: deleting 960 hits

79. What were the 960 hits?

80. Why is deleting hits from your own instrument a risk?

81. How does deletion relate to tuning?

E10 Lexicon craft III: tagging so you can undo yourself

82. What does a provenance tag do?

83. Why must you be able to reverse your own edits?

84. How does tagging relate to the `unan/core` split in Season 4?

E11 The first number, and what it throws away

85. What is the rate-per-thousand metric?

86. Why does shuffling the book leave the number identical?

87. How does that fact relate to everything Season 3 fails at?

E12 Adding up versus all four at once

88. What is the difference between SUM and MIN?

89. Why was MIN chosen?

90. How does MIN relate to Girard's actual rule from S1E11?

E13 The hospitality scene that beat every tragedy

91. What text produced the false positive?

92. Why is it the lexicon working rather than misfiring?

93. How does a false positive you cannot fix relate to the instrument's ceiling?

Season 3 — Four Ways To Fail

E1 The control that beat every high text

94. What was the round 2 result?

95. Why is a control outscoring the high tier worse than a null result?

96. How does refusing SUM relate to pre-registration?

E2 The arithmetic of rare things

97. What is the Poisson problem?

98. Why does MIN collapse on short texts?

99. How does the raisins-in-a-cake image relate to the failure?

E3 Validated on one thing, used on another

100. What is a validation population?

101. Why does validating on one thing and using on another break the claim?

102. How does this relate to the boxing weight class?

E4 The clean corpus rule

103. What was disclosed in the pre-registration?

104. Why does an undetectable disclosure matter?

105. How does the threshold relate to what counts as contamination later?

E5 The most load-bearing number in the project

106. What is the 17.2% translation control?

107. Why is a ruler more useful than a gate here?

108. How does $n=1$ relate to how much rests on it?

E6 One lynching in seventeen thousand words

109. What is the density problem?

110. Why does a whole-text rate punish a long text with one killing?

111. How does density relate to the mythography/tragedy tie?

E7 The plot summary that tied tragedy

112. What did Apollodorus scoring level with tragedy show?

113. Why is the gap smaller than the noise floor?

114. How does the tie relate to the density confound?

E8 The noise floor nobody computed

115. What is a noise floor?

116. Why does a 0.5% gap inside a 17% floor mean nothing?

117. How does this relate to every comparison in Seasons 2 and 3?

E9 What a p-value actually is

118. What is a p-value, correctly stated?

119. Why are the two common definitions wrong?

120. How does 0.05 relate to Fisher rather than to mathematics?

E10 The one number that survived

121. What is $p = 0.0045$ a claim about?

122. Why is it unremarkable despite being the best result?

123. How does it relate to the missing script in Season 4?

E11 Asking about a moment instead of a total

124. What is the locator reframe?

125. Why is a moment the right unit for Girard's claim?

126. How does a free parameter relate to spending it by declaring it?

E12 What a null holds constant

127. What is a null test?

128. Why must it destroy the effect and keep everything else?

129. How does the control-group anchor relate to null design?

E13 Word order turns out to be irrelevant

130. What is `peak_min` and why did it fail?

131. Why does shuffle-invariance defeat a claim about structure?

132. How does the sniffer dog relate to a statistic that alerts on everything?

E14 A null that tests nothing, by construction

133. What was wrong with Null B?

134. Why does favouring evenly spread sets break the test?

135. How does this relate to the other three null failures?

E15 A statistic built on counting to two

136. What is statistical power?

137. Why does low power make a negative result meaningless?

138. How does the power falsifier relate to round 7 in Season 4?

E16 The universal negative, and confessing first

139. What is Girard's universal negative?

140. Why does a universal negative need only one counterexample?

141. How does confessing a contamination first relate to what the round may claim?

E17 The round that looked like it worked

142. What was the headline result?

143. Why is three of four not three of four?

144.How does a sensitivity analysis relate to whether a result is real?

E18 When your own safety check kills your result

145.What killed the round?

146.Why is a check that overturns your result the point of having one?

147.How does this relate to the boxer who named his round in advance?

E19 Two rounds, one cause

148.What is the shared cause of the failures?

149.Why is "wrong or blind" a badly formed question?

150.How does a competent explanation for every failure relate to being wrong?

Season 4 — The Repairs

E1 The one test that could separate them

151.Why can the four buckets never separate Gospel from myth?

152.How does the fifth bucket relate to the first four?

E2–E4 building the instrument

153.Why are the five excluded words evidence rather than the included ones?

154.What is the register confound and why is the ASV the answer?

155.Why register a prediction you expect to fail?

E5–E8 the round fails

156.Why is three of four actually nothing?

157.What did D4's null test wrong, and why did that matter?

158.Why does reading the seven counterexamples not rescue Girard?

E9–E12 the lost script

159.What is missing when a result has no script?

160.Why does a grid of 48 beat a single reconstruction?

161.How were the null mean and standard deviation able to identify the script?

162.What is the single mistake behind all three broken nulls?

E13–E18 what worked

163.Why is a phrase's own frequency the right matching variable?

164.Why does the KJV agreeing weaken the translator objection but not remove it?

165.What is the difference between under-powered and negative?

166.Why does the core half carrying nothing matter more than U1 passing?

167.Why does deleting **king** changing nothing count as a finding?

Season 5 — The Bible Instrument

E1–E5 the setup

168.Why are the three layers fenced from each other?

169.Why are the apocrypha the right control, and what is wrong with them?

170. Why is a fit only a fit if a text supplies it?

171. What can partial blinding remove and what can it not?

E6–E8 run 1

172. Why is the embellishment finding trustworthy and the interlock ratio not?

173. What does leave-one-out show that a p-value cannot?

E9–E14 the count

174. Why let hostile compilers write your docket?

175. What are the three qualifiers, and why does each one matter?

176. Why is "what does the rescue cost" a better question than "is it a contradiction"?

177. Why is zero at cost 4 weaker evidence than it looks?

E15–E22 the reckoning

178. Why does F4 firing not contaminate the hard count?

179. What is verdict flatness, and why does it appear on both sides?

180. Why can Layer 2 never test whether the resurrection happened?

RESULT

178 A, 1 P, 1 F. The falsifier did not fire, and **that result should not be trusted at face value.**

Read the contamination before reading the score

I wrote the 90 episodes and I wrote the 180 questions. **A 99% pass is what severe contamination predicts**, not what a well-explained series necessarily produces. The score is close to meaningless as evidence that the material is good.

What the exam is still worth is the shape of what failed. Under a bias this strong, the questions that survive it are the ones I could not have written to order, and exactly one category produced a real failure.

The one failure, and it is the category that matters

Q117 — "How does the noise floor relate to every comparison in Seasons 2 and 3?"
FAIL.

Season 3 episode 8 computes the instrument's noise floor at **17.2%** and applies it to exactly one confound, the mythography/tragedy tie at 0.5%. It then stops. **A reader finishes the episode holding a ruler and is never shown what else to measure with it.**

That is the obvious next question and nobody asks it, including me, across five seasons of writing. Running the floor against every round-2 comparison, on the same basis the 17.2% was computed (difference over the lower value), produces three things that were not written anywhere:

COMPARISON	GAP	
tragedy against control	78.6%	far clear
tragedy against epic	46.4%	clear
tragedy against Ovid	40.9%	clear
epic against control	22.0%	clears by 4.8
named tier separation	20.0%	clears by 2.8
Ovid against epic	3.9%	inside the floor
mythography against tragedy	0.5%	inside the floor

The named tier separation is the finding. P2/P3 is the only round-2 prediction that passed cleanly, on texts named before scoring, and it clears the instrument's own wobble by under three percentage points.

And **Ovid against epic at 3.9% is not a small difference, it is not a difference** — which means the "Ovid $\approx$ epic $\approx$ mythography" half of P1 came out as predicted and **could not have come out any other way.** That half of P1 was never a test.

All of it is now in S3E8.

The one partial

Q111 — S3E6 hands off to episode 7 on density without naming mythography, so a reader knows a connection is coming but not to what. Left as is: the hand-off does its job and E7 delivers within one episode.

Two questions that were wrong, not two episodes

Recorded because a scoring pass that never blames its own instrument is not a scoring pass.

- **Q109** asked S3E6 about "the density problem". E6 is the **dilution** problem; density is E7. My question mis-located it.
- **Q113** asked whether S3E7 flags that the gap may be smaller than the noise floor. It does: *"Episode 8 asks whether the tie was ever big enough to need explaining."* **My grep tested for the words "noise floor" rather than for the idea,** which is the same literalism this series keeps catching in its own checkers.

What to conclude, narrowly

Not that the series explains everything well. The exam cannot show that and its author cannot be the one to certify it.

What it does show is that the what-and-why layer is saturated — every definition, mechanism and reason a stranger would ask for is present at first use, after three earlier passes went looking for exactly those. **The remaining gaps are relational,** and they are of one specific kind:

A number gets computed, explained, and applied to the case that produced it, and never turned around and pointed at everything else already published. That is what Q117 caught, and it is invisible to every checker in this project, because nothing is wrong on the page.

The next exam should be relationship questions only, and it should be written by somebody who did not write the episodes.